

01

NATURE — Western accounts □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Recommended opening definition: Mystical experience is a mode of religious experience marked, for William James, primarily by ineffability and noetic quality.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Core argument/criticism: James's appeal to transformative fruits avoids reduction by causal origin, but private authority cannot by itself establish public metaphysical truth.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

02

NATURE — Indian accounts □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Recommended opening definition: Advaitic aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation) is direct recognition of the identity of ātman (the true self) and Brahman (ultimate reality).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Core argument/criticism: Unlike episodic subject-object encounter, non-dual realisation claims to dissolve the distinction between knower and known and to become stable knowledge.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Anubhava (direct realisation): in Indian thought the highest religious experience is immediate, intuitive realisation (anubhava/aparokṣānubhūti), not mere belief — the goal of the whole spiritual path. □

ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

03

OBJECT & the question of VERIDICALITY □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

For veridicality: Principle of Credulity (Swinburne) — if it seems to one that X is present, probably X is, absent defeaters; the noetic quality; convergence of mystics.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Hick's pluralist reply: the various experiences are culturally-shaped responses to one ultimate "Real" ("the Real an sich" experienced through different lenses). □

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Core argument/criticism: Credulity, coherence and transformative fruits support prima facie trust, while naturalistic explanation, conflicting reports and private access provide defeaters.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Recommended opening definition: Veridicality asks whether a religious experience presents a real object rather than only a psychologically genuine state.

ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

04

FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

4. □ Aham brahmāsmi is an Upaniṣadic identity formula central to Advaitic interpretation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

1. □ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached by discursive reasoning alone.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Otto names the Holy's distinctive phenomenology mysterium tremendum et fascinans.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. □ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached by discursive reasoning alone.

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached by discursive reasoning alone.

05

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. [James] "Nature & variety of religious experience per William James." (2022) → \$1.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Advaita] "Main features of religious experience in Advaita Vedānta." (2024) → \$2.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Radhakrishnan] "Nature & object of religious experience per Radhakrishnan." (2025) → \$2.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. [James] "Nature & variety of religious experience per William James." (2022) → \$1.

ANSWER LINE: 1. [James] "Nature & variety of religious experience per William James." (2022) → \$1.